

Abuse of Power

Here's Winston Churchill on Clement Attlee saying, he's a modest man, "who has much to be modest about". Or Lyndon Johnson on Gerald Ford, "he's a nice guy, but he played too much football with his helmet off." Two British prime ministers. Two American Presidents. Insults in politics are part of what makes it the *nautanki* we all love so much. But there was a time when rudeness was a fine art, not a fierce assault. Or at least it was practised with some amount of restraint, even when Ram Manohar Lohia called Indira Gandhi a "goongi gudiya" and Morarji Desai called her a "chhokree". Jawaharlal Nehru did not even have the Hindustani vocabulary for such putdowns. As Khushwant Singh says in his new book, the worst he could say was *badtameez* or *bewakoof*. He did, of course, let fly in other ways occasionally, such as slapping the president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee because the microphone he was speaking into went dead, or beating some people who were jostling him with a large, dishevelled bouquet.

Compare it with what we have in this election. There's Akhilesh Das getting his 15 seconds of fame by questioning Nafisa Ali's marital status. Here's Rabri Devi calling JD(U) President Rajiv Ranjan Singh 'Lalan' Nitish Kumar's "saala". And there again is Sanjay Dutt offering to give a *jhappi* and a *pappi* to Mayawati—as if. It's the politics of the gutter, where coarse abuse has replaced dignified discourse, where Parliament has been replaced by the street, where well-read politicians have been bodily exchanged for those who are qualified only to scan bank statements or maybe FIRS. What else explains the nastiness of a supposedly educated young man like Varun Gandhi? Granted, his mother did once call her own mother-in-law a goddess who drinks human blood, but it's not genes alone. The man who inducted Varun into the BJP once compared Sonia Gandhi to Monica Lewinsky and the man who heads his party is best known now for calling his opponent a *nikamma* prime minister.

Just as well we don't have television debates in India. Can you imagine Manmohan Singh squaring off against L.K Advani on television? With Singh's new found mojo, he will probably be sending Advani into the corner to weep, just as he says he did after his "only achievement", demolishing the Babri Masjid. BJP workers have apparently been telling their spokespersons to be far more aggressive, not to walk on eggshells around the Congress, which seems to have taken inspiration from Sonia Gandhi's *maut ka saudagar* remark of 2007, and is going for the jugular—yes, even sweet little Rahul. Invective is the imperative of the times, it seems. Perfect for a generation that watches reality shows where cuss words outnumber everyday phrases. And probably thinks two weeks in jail is a small price to pay for four weeks of becoming breaking news.



LAUNCHED: By ISRO, an all-weather Israeli-built spy satellite **RISAT-2** that will help security agencies keep a close vigil on the country's borders.



APPOINTED: Hardeep Singh Puri, secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs, as India's permanent representative to the United Nations. Puri will succeed Nirupam Sen, whose term ended March 31.

AWARDED: Journalist Neerja Chaudhary the Prem Bhatia Award for her contribution to the field of political reporting.

SENTENCED: Abdul Karim Toig, the main accused in the multi-crore fake stamp paper case, to seven years rigorous imprisonment by a CBI special sessions court.



SAURABH SINGH